SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE: LAWS, RULES, CONSCIENCE

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE → LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND → LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY → ETHICS IN MAKING RULES → CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION → CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g2 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP · CENTRAL FOCUS · 1. SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP · (1) CONSCIENCE SIGNALS AN INTERNAL MORAL CONCERN. · (2) FAMILY AND SOCIAL LEARNING SHAPE EARLY MORAL JUDGMENT. · (3) PROFESSIONAL ETHICS ARTICULATE OCCUPATIONAL VALUES. · (4) CONDUCT CODES SPECIFY INSTITUTIONAL EXPECTATIONS. · (5) SERVICE RULES GOVERN DEFINED OFFICIAL CONDUCT.

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Sources of ethical guidance map → (1) Conscience signals an internal moral concern. → (2) Family and social learning shape early moral judgment.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 1. Sources of ethical guidance map
- (1) Conscience signals an internal moral concern.
- (2) Family and social learning shape early moral judgment.
- (3) Professional ethics articulate occupational values.

MECHANISM

- (4) Conduct codes specify institutional expectations.
- (5) Service rules govern defined official conduct.
- (6) Regulations operate under delegated legal authority.
- (7) Statutes establish binding public legal standards.
- (8) Constitutional limits test all public authority.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- VERDICT → Treat the sources as interacting checks, not as a mechanical ladder that legalises every compliant act.
- ANSWER USE → Use for an opening definition map before resolving a law-rule-conscience conflict.
- MUST REMEMBER: Constitution, statute, delegated legislation, service rule, code,...

MECHANISM / VERDICT — MUST REMEMBER: Constitution, statute, delegated legislation, service rule, code,...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER USE — Use for an opening definition map before resolving a law-rule-conscience conflict.

01

STAGE 01

LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION

LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 2. LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION · (1) START WITH CONSTITUTIONAL COMPETENCE AND RIGHTS. · (2) IDENTIFY THE PARENT STATUTE AND ITS PURPOSE. · (3) LOCATE ANY DELEGATED RULE-MAKING POWER. · (4) CHECK WHETHER A VALID RULE APPLIES. · (5) IDENTIFY REGULATOR-MADE REGULATIONS, IF ANY.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 2. Law, rule, regulation and instruction → (1) Start with constitutional competence and rights. → (2) Identify the parent statute and its purpose. → (3) Locate any delegated rule-making power.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 2. Law, rule, regulation and instruction
- (1) Start with constitutional competence and rights.
- (2) Identify the parent statute and its purpose.

MECHANISM

- (3) Locate any delegated rule-making power.
- (4) Check whether a valid rule applies.
- (5) Identify regulator-made regulations, if any.
- (6) Separate circulars and guidelines from regulations.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Check service-rule or contractual adoption of codes.
- (8) Record the instrument's legal force.
- VERDICT → Never call every office instruction a law or every guideline delegated legislation.
- ANSWER USE → Use in the 2020 laws-versus-rules answer and in rule-of-law case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER USE — Use in the 2020 laws-versus-rules answer and in rule-of-law case studies.

02

STAGE 02

LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY

LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY · CENTRAL FOCUS · 3. LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY · (1) ASK WHETHER THE ACTOR HAS LEGAL AUTHORITY. · (2) CHECK COMPLIANCE WITH APPLICABLE RULE AND PROCEDURE. · (3) IDENTIFY THE PUBLIC PURPOSE OF THE POWER. · (4) TEST FAIRNESS AND EQUAL TREATMENT. · (5) MAP FORESEEABLE HARMS AND BENEFITS.

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
CENTRAL FOCUS	(1) Identify the public purpose of the power.	(7) Assess trust and institutional precedent.
3. Legality, ethics and propriety	(4) Test fairness and equal treatment.	(8) State a qualified ethical-propriety verdict.
(1) Ask whether the actor has legal authority.	(5) Map foreseeable harms and benefits.	VERDICT → Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.
(2) Check compliance with applicable rule and procedure.	(6) Check conflicts, gifts and appearance of bias.	ANSWER USE → Use to structure a legal-but-unethical example without implying that ethics overrides law.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 3. Legality, ethics and propriety
- (1) Ask whether the actor has legal authority.
- (2) Check compliance with applicable rule and procedure.

MECHANISM

- (1) Identify the public purpose of the power.
- (4) Test fairness and equal treatment.
- (5) Map foreseeable harms and benefits.
- (6) Check conflicts, gifts and appearance of bias.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Assess trust and institutional precedent.
- (8) State a qualified ethical-propriety verdict.
- VERDICT → Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.
- ANSWER USE → Use to structure a legal-but-unethical example without implying that ethics overrides law.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.

03

STAGE 03

ETHICS IN MAKING RULES

ETHICS IN MAKING RULES · CENTRAL FOCUS · 4. ETHICS IN MAKING RULES · (1) DEFINE THE LEGITIMATE PUBLIC OBJECTIVE. · (2) IDENTIFY AFFECTED GROUPS AND UNEQUAL BURDENS. · (3) CHOOSE AUTHORITY CONSISTENT WITH THE PARENT LAW. · (4) MAKE CRITERIA INTELLIGIBLE AND TRANSPARENT. · (5) TEST PROPORTIONALITY OF RESTRICTIONS AND SANCTIONS.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 4. Ethics in making rules → (1) Define the legitimate public objective. → (2) Identify affected groups and unequal burdens. → (3) Choose authority consistent with the parent law.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 4. Ethics in making rules
- (1) Define the legitimate public objective.
- (2) Identify affected groups and unequal burdens.

MECHANISM

- (3) Choose authority consistent with the parent law.
- (4) Make criteria intelligible and transparent.
- (5) Test proportionality of restrictions and sanctions.
- (6) Build access and accommodation where authorised.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Provide reasons, appeal and review mechanisms.
- (8) Revise after evidence of exclusion or harm.
- VERDICT → Ethics improves legitimacy, fairness and implementation; it does not create delegated power.
- ANSWER USE → Use for the second half of 2020 GS-IV Q4(a).

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Ethics improves legitimacy, fairness and implementation; it does not create delegated power.

04

STAGE 04

CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION

CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 5. CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION · (1) IDENTIFY THE CONSTITUTIONAL VALUE IN ISSUE. · (2) CHECK COMPETENCE AND LEGAL AUTHORITY. · (3) PROTECT EQUALITY AND NON-ARBITRARINESS. · (4) RESPECT DIGNITY AND AFFECTED-PERSON VOICE. · (5) FOLLOW DUE PROCESS AND FAIR HEARING.

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Constitutional morality in administration → (1) Identify the constitutional value in issue. → (2) Check competence and legal authority.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 5. Constitutional morality in administration
- (1) Identify the constitutional value in issue.
- (2) Check competence and legal authority.

MECHANISM

- (3) Protect equality and non-arbitrariness.
- (4) Respect dignity and affected-person voice.
- (5) Follow due process and fair hearing.
- (6) Give intelligible public reasons.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Resist majoritarian or partisan pressure.
- (8) Accept competent review and correction.
- VERDICT → Constitutional morality disciplines both majority pressure and private preference.
- ANSWER USE → Use for the 2019 and 2025 constitutional-morality routes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Constitutional morality disciplines both majority pressure and private preference.

05

STAGE 05

CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE

CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE · CENTRAL FOCUS · 6. CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE · (1) NOTICE THE MORAL ALARM OR DISCOMFORT. · (2) COLLECT FACTS INSTEAD OF ACTING ON IMPULSE. · (3) NAME THE AFFECTED STAKEHOLDERS AND HARMS. · (4) CHECK PERSONAL BIAS AND INCOMPLETE INFORMATION. · (5) IDENTIFY APPLICABLE LAW AND SERVICE RULES.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 6. Calibrating conscience → (1) Notice the moral alarm or discomfort. → (2) Collect facts instead of acting on impulse. → (3) Name the affected stakeholders and harms.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 6. Calibrating conscience
- (1) Notice the moral alarm or discomfort.
- (2) Collect facts instead of acting on impulse.

MECHANISM

- (3) Name the affected stakeholders and harms.
- (4) Check personal bias and incomplete information.
- (5) Identify applicable law and service rules.
- (6) Test constitutional values and public purpose.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Consult a competent institutional channel.
- (8) Record a revisable reasoned conclusion.
- VERDICT → Conscience is an ethical signal that becomes reliable through evidence and public reasoning.
- ANSWER USE → Use for 2023 GS-IV Q7(a) and conscience-based case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Conscience is an ethical signal that becomes reliable through evidence and public reasoning.

06

STAGE 06

CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER

CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER · CENTRAL FOCUS · 7. CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER · (1) DEFINE THE INSTRUCTION AND MORAL CONFLICT PRECISELY. · (2) VERIFY FACTS, LAW AND SERIOUSNESS OF HARM. · (3) REFLECT AND SEEK ETHICAL OR LEGAL CLARIFICATION. · (4) PLACE A FACTUAL WRITTEN OBJECTION ON RECORD. · (5) SEEK RECUSAL ONLY WHERE AUTHORITY PERMITS IT.

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Crisis of conscience response ladder → (1) Define the instruction and moral conflict precisely. → (2) Verify facts, law and seriousness of harm.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 7. Crisis of conscience response ladder
- (1) Define the instruction and moral conflict precisely.
- (2) Verify facts, law and seriousness of harm.

MECHANISM

- (3) Reflect and seek ethical or legal clarification.
- (4) Place a factual written objection on record.
- (5) Seek recusal only where authority permits it.
- (6) Escalate to a competent superior or oversight body.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Report verified wrongdoing through available channels.
- (8) Consider resignation only after grave unresolved complicity.
- VERDICT → Use the lowest effective accountable channel, not silent compliance or immediate public defiance.
- ANSWER USE → Use in the 2019 crisis-of-conscience answer and public-service dilemmas.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Use the lowest effective accountable channel, not silent compliance or immediate public defiance.

07

STAGE 07

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT · CENTRAL FOCUS · 8. CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT · (1) CITIZEN IDENTIFIES AN UNJUST LAW OR POLICY. · (2) CIVIL RESISTANCE IS PUBLIC AND COMMUNICATIVE. · (3) NON-VIOLENCE LIMITS COERCIVE HARM. · (4) ACCEPTANCE OF CONSEQUENCE SIGNALS PRINCIPLED PROTEST. · (5) PUBLIC SERVANT HOLDS DELEGATED OFFICIAL AUTHORITY.

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
CENTRAL FOCUS	(3) Non-violence limits coercive harm.	(7) Dissent begins with review and escalation channels.
8. Civil disobedience versus institutional dissent	(4) Acceptance of consequence signals principled protest.	(8) External action needs necessity and proportionality.
(1) Citizen identifies an unjust law or policy.	(5) Public servant holds delegated official authority.	VERDICT → Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.
(2) Civil resistance is public and communicative.	(6) Office duty requires records and confidentiality.	ANSWER USE → Use to distinguish principled resistance from unaccountable disclosure.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 8. Civil disobedience versus institutional dissent
- (1) Citizen identifies an unjust law or policy.
- (2) Civil resistance is public and communicative.

MECHANISM

- (3) Non-violence limits coercive harm.
- (4) Acceptance of consequence signals principled protest.
- (5) Public servant holds delegated official authority.
- (6) Office duty requires records and confidentiality.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Dissent begins with review and escalation channels.
- (8) External action needs necessity and proportionality.
- VERDICT → Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.
- ANSWER USE → Use to distinguish principled resistance from unaccountable disclosure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.

08

STAGE 08

WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS

WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS · CENTRAL FOCUS · 9. WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS · (1) IDENTIFY EVIDENCE OF SERIOUS WRONGDOING OR HARM. · (2) SEPARATE FACT FROM POLICY DISAGREEMENT OR GRIEVANCE. · (3) PRESERVE MATERIAL LAWFULLY AND CONFIDENTIALLY. · (4) ASSESS IMMEDIATE PUBLIC-INTEREST URGENCY. · (5) USE THE LEAST COMPROMISED COMPETENT RECIPIENT.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 9. Whistleblowing and protected channels
- (1) Identify evidence of serious wrongdoing or harm.
- (2) Separate fact from policy disagreement or grievance.

MECHANISM

- (3) Preserve material lawfully and confidentially.
- (4) Assess immediate public-interest urgency.
- (5) Use the least compromised competent recipient.
- (6) Verify current protection and confidentiality scope.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Document retaliation risk and requested safeguard.
- (8) Seek independent review of response or inaction.
- VERDICT → Whistleblowing is evidence-based public-interest reporting, not an automatic entitlement to leak.
- ANSWER USE → Use for the 2022 protection route and conscience-to-accountability answers.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Whistleblowing is evidence-based public-interest reporting, not an automatic entitlement to leak.

09

STAGE 09

SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST

SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST · CENTRAL FOCUS · 10. SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST · (1) SPECIFY THE ALLEGED PUBLIC WRONG. · (2) VERIFY EVIDENCE AND CREDIBILITY OF THE CONCERN. · (3) MAP PRIVACY, TRANSPARENCY AND SECURITY VALUES. · (4) ASSESS REALISTIC INTERNAL OVERSIGHT CHANNELS. · (5) TEST WHETHER THOSE CHANNELS ARE INADEQUATE.

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. Snowden-type external disclosure test → (1) Specify the alleged public wrong. → (2) Verify evidence and credibility of the concern.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 10. Snowden-type external disclosure test
- (1) Specify the alleged public wrong.
- (2) Verify evidence and credibility of the concern.
- (3) Map privacy, transparency and security values.

MECHANISM

- (4) Assess realistic internal oversight channels.
- (5) Test whether those channels are inadequate.
- (6) Consider narrower authorised disclosure alternatives.
- (7) Minimise avoidable harm to uninvolved persons.
- (8) Give a qualified necessity- proportionality verdict.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- VERDICT → A serious conscience claim strengthens only when method, necessity and proportionality also withstand scrutiny.
- ANSWER USE → Use for 2018 GS-IV Q12 without treating the question's legal claims as settled facts.
- CLOSE DISTINCTION: A crisis of conscience is a serious conflict among justified...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — A serious conscience claim strengthens only when method, necessity and proportionality also withstand scrutiny.

10

STAGE 10

FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION

FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 11. FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION · (1) IDENTIFY THE STATUTORY OR SCHEME PURPOSE. · (2) READ THE APPLICABLE RULE AND ITS EXCEPTION. · (3) ESTABLISH RELEVANT FACTS AND AFFECTED INTERESTS. · (4) CHECK WHETHER EQUIVALENT COMPLIANCE IS AUTHORISED. · (5) TREAT SIMILARLY PLACED PERSONS ALIKE.

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Form, substance and reasoned discretion → (1) Identify the statutory or scheme purpose. → (2) Read the applicable rule and its exception.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 11. Form, substance and reasoned discretion
- (1) Identify the statutory or scheme purpose.
- (2) Read the applicable rule and its exception.
- (3) Establish relevant facts and affected interests.

MECHANISM

- (4) Check whether equivalent compliance is authorised.
- (5) Treat similarly placed persons alike.
- (6) Reject ultra-vires or selective waiver.
- (7) Record authority, alternatives and reasons.
- (8) Enable audit, appeal and judicial review.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- VERDICT → Substance corrects mechanical literalism only within authority, equality and review safeguards.
- ANSWER USE → Use for 2024 Q4(b) and discretionary welfare or procurement cases.
- EVIDENCE / AUTHORITY / APPLICATION LIMIT: For Snowden or Indian vigilance examples,...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Substance corrects mechanical literalism only within authority, equality and review safeguards.

11

STAGE 11

ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS

ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS · CENTRAL FOCUS · 12. ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS · (1) DEFINE THE PRECISE SOURCE-OF-GUIDANCE ISSUE. · (2) DISTINGUISH LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND CODE. · (3) IDENTIFY CONSTITUTIONAL VALUE AND LEGAL AUTHORITY. · (4) STATE THE ETHICAL HARM OR PUBLIC-INTEREST CONCERN. · (5) TEST CONSCIENCE AGAINST FACTS AND BIAS.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 12. Answer-writing synthesis → (1) Define the precise source-of-guidance issue. → (2) Distinguish law, rule, regulation and code. → (3) Identify constitutional value and legal authority.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 12. Answer-writing synthesis
- (1) Define the precise source-of-guidance issue.
- (2) Distinguish law, rule, regulation and code.

MECHANISM

- (3) Identify constitutional value and legal authority.
- (4) State the ethical harm or public-interest concern.
- (5) Test conscience against facts and bias.
- (6) Choose institutional channel and safeguard.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- (7) Use a named Indian administrative illustration.
- (8) Conclude with a qualified accountable verdict.
- VERDICT → High-scoring answers combine ethical sensitivity with lawful, evidence-based institutional action.
- ANSWER USE → Use as the final revision checklist for theory questions and case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — High-scoring answers combine ethical sensitivity with lawful, evidence-based institutional action.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · 1. ARCHITECTURE · 2. CONCEPTS AND DISTINCTIONS · 3. DETAILED TREATMENT · 4. INSTITUTIONAL AND REFORM ARCHITECTURE · 5. INDIAN APPLICATIONS AND BOUNDARY CASES · 6. LIMITATIONS AND TRADE-OFFS · 7. MUST-KNOW FACTS FOR ADVANCED PRELIMS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- 1. Architecture
- 2. Concepts and distinctions
- 3. Detailed treatment
- 4. Institutional and reform architecture

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 5. Indian applications and boundary cases
- 6. Limitations and trade-offs
- 7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims
- 8. Advanced Prelims traps

LEGACY / NUANCE

- 9. Current-anchor application
- 10. PYQ-based analytical application
- 11. Mains-ready framework
- 12. Probable questions

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels